position was very similar to Bairam Khan's, in fact, for his king was 'careless of worldly affairs'.[22] Unlike Bairam Khan's young protégé, moreover, Adil was unlikely to develop an ability to rule, while Hemu's talents were only just beginning to flower.

Even Abul Fazl, whose resentment of Hemu's challenge to Akbar knows few bounds, admits that he 'waged great wars . . . [with] valour and daring' and 'performed great deeds'. Badauni, too, has a bias against Hemu, though his grudge is more personal: Badauni's father's library was destroyed during one of Hemu's campaigns. It is Badauni, moreover, who provides a glimpse of Hemu's ruthless pursuit of victory.

As various would-be monarchs marched across the north Indian plains, the people of Hindustan faced a far more pressing concern – they were battling a famine. The hunger was particularly severe around Delhi and Agra. People ate whatever they could find: thorns, herbs, animal hide – even each other. Some 'would join together and carry off a solitary man and make him their food', writes Abul Fazl; Badauni swears he saw it with his own eyes. It was under such grim conditions that Hemu launched a three-month siege of Bayana, south of Agra; and throughout, writes Badauni, while 'the people died with the word "bread" upon their lips', Hemu fed his elephants rice, sugar and butter, and would host a grand public meal every day himself, encouraging his Afghan soldiers to eat in 'large handfuls . . . "How can you with such a slender appetite expect to fight with any rascally Mughal"'!

It is possible that Badauni is exaggerating or ill-informed; he would have been a boy at the time and an unlikely witness to the scene. On the other hand, a show of plenty was commonly used as psy-ops during a siege[23] – it would be testament to Hemu's strategic mind, not a condemnation of his cold heart.

Whatever the case may be, Hemu won the siege of Bayana, as he won every battle he fought on Adil's behalf, while Adil appeared nowhere on the scene. It was only a matter of time, then, before the general's eye turned to the crown, and thus, to Delhi.

On 6 October 1556, eight months after Akbar's enthronement in Kalanaur, Hemu led 50,000 men and 1000 elephants, equipped with 500 mortar guns and fifty-one cannons, to the outskirts of Delhi. Akbar was still in Punjab,